



and select Use Large icons in the menu under Effects button

Windows Accessibility Tools and Shortcuts: Open Start Menu > All Programs > Accessories > Accessibility/Ease of Access. The Magnifier tool allows you to see magnified areas of your screen in a separate pane. You can place the pane on any side of the screen and can also invert colours when needed. The Narrator tool narrates everything that is present on-screen. The On-Screen Keyboard tool provides a keyboard in your display. This is particularly useful if the touchscreen has been setup.

The Windows Speech Recognition tool allows you to configure the computer to recognise a voice. Once it is configured, this tool can be used to Open Applications and Folders, Dictate text and perform multiple actions via voice commands. One of the simplest features of this application is to show numbers for every action on screen for the command 'Show Numbers', where choosing a number behaves as a single click. This is particularly useful when the pronunciations for an action do not match what the computer is expecting.

Keyboard Settings: Go to Start > Control Panel > Accessibility Options and open the Keyboard tab. The options you have here are StickyKeys, ToggleKeys and FilterKeys.

Enabling StickyKeys makes Ctrl, Alt, Shift and Windows behave as pressed until the next keystroke even if the user has let go of it. Enabling ToggleKeys notifies the user of pressing ScrollLock, CapsLock or NumLock with a sound. Enabling FilterKeys makes the keyboard ignore rapid keystrokes or keystrokes in quick succession.

Mouse settings: Using the mouse can be made a lot easier by tweaking some settings under Control Panel > Mouse. For example, setting the Double-click speed to low allows for better detection of slow double clicks. Also, under Pointer tab, you can toggle the last checkbox to show the location of the mouse when you press Ctrl.

Software to make it simpler

There are a number of proprietary software in the market that simplify the entire windows experience by adding a UI layer

and Hotkeys on top of the existing OS. For example, Envelope from Simplicity Computers can run off a USB stick and provide a highly simplified Envelope-like



The Eldy UI has a very easy-to-use and friendly approach.

interface, as its name suggests, with four sections divided into four simple actions at a time. For example, opening the Email tab gives you options to Read Email, Write Email, see your Address book. The fourth tab in any screen is reserved for Tutorials, which take the user through the actions for that screen. The basic USB stick with the software is priced at 69 Pounds, or roughly ₹6,500.

A free alternative to this is Eldy, which can be downloaded at <http://dgit.in/Eldy-Dwnld>. The software is even more acces-



The Accessibility centre provides a lot of easy to use grouped options

sible and comes with Skype integration support. A lot of thought has gone into the design of the interface, as is evident from the separate buttons for "@" and several standard actions like Cut-Copy-Paste. Although it does have its share of problems with the help section being in Italian in one version, it is completely elderly oriented right from the point of installation to the close button.

Maintaining the PC – The essential tools for remote access

Your responsibility is not over once you have made the system easy to use. Any computer, elder friendly or not, requires maintenance. Especially the ones which will be used by elders might be more prone to accidental failures. For the times when you are not present there, you may still need to remotely access the machine. Out of the remote access software available, TeamViewer is the best as it offers both attended and unattended usage. That is, you can work on the machine even when it is being used by the person. Here's how you can go forward setting it up:

Step 1: Download and Install TeamViewer software on both the controlling and the controllable machine, from the TeamViewer website. You need administrator access to do this.

Step 2: Select 'Personal/Non-Commercial' use when prompted during installation for free usage

Step 3: After installing, run TeamViewer on both machines.

Step 4: Enter your User ID and password to log into the client, and then enter your partner's ID to establish a desktop sharing session.

Step 5: Select Remote Control and click on Connect to Partner.

Step 6: When prompted, enter the password provided by your partner from the partner machine. You should now be able to see and have full access of the partner computer.

Conclusion

Setting up the proper hardware, software and applications as shown above can enable the elderly in your house to finally start using a computer without feeling anxious. Beyond all these tweaks that you do for them, they deserve the same patience and dedication that they showered upon you as a kid. And there's much in it for you too. Remember the first time they taught you something that you thought impossible otherwise? Wouldn't you like to see them feel the same happiness because you made it possible?